

# Built Worlds, Built Knowledge: Disability, Space, and Epistemic Exclusion

By Roxy Alexander

*Oppression is driven not by individual, unconscious syndromes but by social ideologies that are embodied, and precisely because ideologies are embodied, their effects are readable, and must be read, in the construction and history of societies.*

Siebers 2008, 32

## Introduction

Though critical theory has intended to center those in the periphery, canon literature within the practice has largely erased disability from its scholarship (Sami Schalk 2022) and neglected to investigate the category of disability as an equally harmful socially constructed identity. As consequence, modern critical theorists frequently omit from their work effective inquiries that consider embodied differences and how the exclusion of such differences in thought influence the built world. I find that this omission epistemically constrains the critical lens to an ableist hermeneutics.

To leave out the experiences of disabled communities from critical theory is a grave injustice, one that harms far more people than just those considered disabled. Accordingly, my argument seeks to provide conceptual clarity of the genealogical model of disability and acknowledge the circular causality between the production of physical space and the production of knowledge. First, by way of laying out the foundational theory of this paper, I will outline the traditional definition given by disability scholars for the different models of disability and subsequently re-introduce the historical model as the genealogical model of disability. The second section will consider the mutually reinforcing relationship between the built world and knowledge from an epistemological framework. The third section will be an application of the

analyses made in section two to real world cases, 6 how ableist norms and inaccessible architecture are mutually reinforcing. The subsequent sections will cover universal design as articulated in the architectural discipline and prove its success by uplifting real-world applications. Overall, the contribution of this paper is to extend genealogical disability theory into social epistemology by demonstrating how built environments themselves can enact epistemic oppression, thereby shaping who is allowed to participate in public discourse.

## Section One: The Genealogical Model of Disability

This section will introduce the different models by which society looks at disability. First, I will provide an explanation for the moral model of disability and the medical model of disability. Then I will introduce the social model of disability and its shortcomings that led to the development of the historical model of disability. Finally, I will re-introduce the historical model as the genealogical model, explaining how the model views disability and providing a basis for why changing the name is prudent.

Throughout history the cause of disability has been portrayed in many ways. Under the moral model of disability, disabled individuals are seen as living the consequences of their own, or their families, moral failure (Dunn 2022). Often disabled individuals are portrayed under this model as monsters, beasts, ogres, or freaks. In fiction, the moral model is used as a narrative tool to teach lessons or to background the insurmountable hurdle the protagonist somehow overcomes by the end of the story. The conflation of disability with cursed monstrosity is a popular narrative device for stories aimed to teach moral lessons. In *Beauty and the Beast*, a witch is hurt by the prince's shallowness and curses him to a life of isolation and despair, turning the prince into the Beast. He only overcomes his curse (disability) when Belle falls in love with him. This narrative device creates a sense of urgency within the budding relationship between Belle and the Beast.

The larger moral lesson being taught is that it is not looks that matter; it is what's on the inside that counts. Yet, using disability negatively to teach moral lessons paints disabled individuals both as outwardly monstrous and inwardly immoral, pitiable, or someone to be saved.

Like the moral model, the medical model of disability frames embodied differences as something that can be overcome. In this model, disability is pathologized and can be cured through medical or technological intervention. This model is the current lens through which Western society sees disabled individuals, arising during the ascent of medicalization following scientific and technological advancements. As a result, society-at-large considers disability as “an individual defect lodged in the person, a defect that must be cured or eliminated if the person is to achieve full capacity as a human being” (Siebers 2008). This belief can be seen in the interventions chosen – pharmaceuticals – to treat cognitive conditions such as ADHD, Schizophrenia, Borderline Personality Disorder, and more. It is because these are the initial and often only interventions that we can identify the medical model at play. Repeatedly, disability under the medical model framing is nothing more than a defect originating *within* the individual; a physical or mental ailment that restricts individuals from being a part of larger social networks, including spaces of knowledge production. With the help of medicine or assistive technology, disabled individuals can overcome their deficiencies and reach their fullest potential.

Both the medical model and the moral model are based within, reinforce, and naturalize ableist thinking. Talia Lewis defines ableism as:

A system that places value on people's bodies and minds based on societally constructed ideas of normality, intelligence, excellence, desirability, and productivity. These constructed ideas are deeply rooted in anti-Blackness, eugenics, misogyny, colonialism, imperialism, and capitalism. This form of systemic oppression leads to people and society determining who is valuable and worthy based on a person's language, appearance, religion and/or their ability to satisfactorily [re]produce, excel and “behave.” You do not have to be disabled to experience ableism (TALILA LEWIS 2025).

The moral model holds individuals up against a collective notion of normality and excellence, faulting anyone who strays away from the norm. This non-normalcy is taken up as an indicator of the individual's morality and value. Similarly, the medical model compares individuals to the ideal bodymind – healthy, intelligent, mobile, productive. Instead of assigning a moral valence to non-ideal bodyminds, this model pathologizes bodyminds that differ from the ideal. It then justifies medical interventions meant to bring non-ideal bodyminds closer to the ideal by claiming a desire to make the lives of disabled people easier by “fixing” them. Both models operate from the ableist belief that disability is an individual ailment (moral or biological) that one can medically fix or morally overcome. Disability scholars do not view disability as arising within the individual.

As disability scholar Joseph Shapiro stated in his book *No Pity: People with Disabilities Forging a New Civil Rights Movement*, many disability scholars prescribe to the social model of disability, understanding disability as socially constructed identity (Shapiro 1994). Social models of disability hold that the socially and physically constructed world prevent individuals with embodied differences from full participation in social life. Under such models, “disability is not a physical or mental defect but a cultural and minority identity. To call disability an identity is to recognize that it is not a biological or natural property but an elastic social category both subject to social control and capable of effecting social change” (Siebers 2008). Siebers characterization of disability as a socially constructed identity is reflecting the belief that impairment and disability have different loci.

The bodymind is the locus of impairment. Under social models, impairment is not inherently negative; it is simply an embodied difference. For example, a paraplegic person has a mobility impairment and may use a wheelchair. They are impaired, not disabled. They become

functionally disabled by the social, environmental, and ideological barriers that prevent them from fully accessing and participating in society. A paraplegic student becomes functionally disabled when their ability to access the science lab is prevented because there is not a ramp entrance or an elevator (Thomson 1997,7). A Deaf person becomes functionally disabled when the design of a room limits the visibility of the door. I become functionally disabled when the overhead lights are too bright. Focusing on how built spaces functionally disable people diverts attention away from the bodymind and instead towards “the social meanings, symbols, and stigmas attached to disability identity” (Siebers 2008, 3). The social model of disability highlights the interrelationship between the theoretical and physical, addressing *what* the social ideology is that has materialized in the physical world and how such materializations regulate who gets in and who stays out.

A critique of the social model is its under-theorization of chronic illness and its bifurcation of material embodiment and social life (Shakespeare 1998; Wendell 2013). To contend with the short fallings of the social model, disability scholars Lennard J. Davis and Shelly Tremain have fortified the social model, renaming the upgrade to the historical model of disability. Davis’s addition pushed for a deeper understanding of corporeal variability; the reality that disability is not always something a person is born with; one may become / unbecome disabled at any point. His argument pushed forward disability as an unstable category that transcends identity politics due to its temporal nature. Tremain on the other hand suggests a Foucauldian interpretation of how disability has been socially constructed. In a piece on these different models, Joel M. Reynolds summarizes Tremain’s argument:

Tremain’s overarching point is not merely that the concept of “impairment” is historically produced and contestable, but that it was specifically produced by governmental and juridical practices to control particular populations. Namely, those judged less valuable to

the social and economic order and thus made fungible for enslavement, institutionalization, or other forms of state-sanctioned control (Reynolds 2022).

Tremain's Foucauldian reading foregrounds the mutually reinforcing relationship between time and ideology, fitting well with Talia Lewis's definition for ableism. I like this reading of disability as a socio-temporally constructed identity because it puts disability in conversation with biopower. While I like the content of the historical model of disability, I think the name is slightly misleading. My suggestion is that we refer to it instead as the genealogical model of disability. This name nods to Foucault's method of genealogy and informs by name an approach that traces how disability develops over time through historical, social, political, and material forces. A genealogical model of disability examines disability as a category that has been produced over time through laws, institutions, medicalization, social norms, architecture, and ideology, and how these forces mutually reinforce each other. Unlike the social model, the genealogical model treats disability as historically, politically, and discursively constructed, emphasizing power, temporality, and space. It is this model that grounds my view of the world and this paper. Therefore, it will be through this model that I epistemically consider the mutually reinforcing relationship between the built world and knowledge.

## Section Two: Design $\leftrightarrow$ Knowledge

***"Knowledge is socially situated [...] Identities are socially constructed  
[...] Some bodies are excluded by dominant social ideologies [...]"***

Tobin 2008, 33

Building on social epistemology and extending the work of Kristie Dotson, this section makes the argument that the physical world reinforces the epistemic oppression of disabled communities. First, I will outline the concepts epistemic exclusion, epistemic oppression, and epistemic disablement. Then I will argue that the historically, politically, and discursively

constructed category of disability has manifested itself within the physically built world. Further, I will argue that the public, physical world is co-constitutive with mainstream knowledge and inaccessible spaces create physical checkpoints that regulate contribution to knowledge production. Lastly, I will argue that such spatial ruling leads to the regulation of knowledge and thus the epistemic oppression of disabled communities.

Epistemology is the study of how we form, justify, share, and understand knowledge. Epistemic is a term used within epistemology to name that which is related to knowledge. Epistemic agents are individuals that have the ability “to utilize persuasively shared epistemic resources within a given community of knowers in order to participate in knowledge production and, if required, the revision of those same resources” (Dotson 2014). Within the last two decades, social epistemologists have focused their attention to the ways in which epistemic agents are excluded and oppressed from and by knowledge production. Kristie Dotson defines epistemic oppression as the “[...] persistent epistemic exclusion that hinders one’s contribution to knowledge production” (Dotson 2014, 115). A hinderance to one’s knowledge contribution is considered epistemic exclusion when it is “an unwarranted infringement on the epistemic agency of knowers” (Dotson 2014, 115). In other words, the epistemic agent is excluded without just reason.

Often, social epistemologists consider interpersonal communications to be the locus for this oppression because they believe that the exchange and production of knowledge take place first and foremost (or so they believe) between two or more epistemic agents. I disagree with this consideration.

Epistemic oppression does not require a human agent to enact it. Epistemic oppression occurs, as noted by Dotson, when one’s epistemic contribution is unjustly hindered. There is no

specification as to *who*, or more aptly, *what* is hindering the contribution. The built world unjustly hinders epistemic agents from contributing to mainstream knowledge production by governing who can access spaces of knowledge production. Most often, the individuals that are epistemically oppressed by the built world are the same individuals functionally disabled by the built world. This is epistemic disablement.

Epistemic disablement has been defined by Amandine Catala, Luc Faucher, and Pierre Poirier as “[A] process that effectively removes the possibility for an individual or a group of individuals to engage in fair epistemic interactions and to successfully make fruitful epistemic contributions” (Catala et al. 2021, ). The built world works as a part of the process in which individuals are epistemically disabled. This term arises out of scholarship framed within the genealogical model of disability, and locates the problem not in the person but in the world: “The problem here is not that autistic people are inherently impaired in their epistemic capacities but, rather, that some features of the neurotypical environment offer epistemic disaffordances: they constitute an impediment to fair and fruitful epistemic interactions” (Catala et al. 2021, 9031). For Catala et al., the built world reflects neurotypicality. I would go one further and say that it reflects the environment from which non-disabled bodyminds function best. Spaces then functionally disable anyone whose bodymind skews from the socially constructed ideal because the world does not cater to the needs of those outside this ideal. When the environment is mis-attuned with an individual’s bodymind, the individual faces epistemic disaffordances and finds themselves restricted in their epistemic interactions.

When spoken of at a theoretical level, the issue of inaccessible spaces effecting epistemic production seems trivial. One might ask *how can a building influence what we know?* I find it best to answer this question with an example that is close to home. Consider Hurst Hall, a



historic building on American University's campus. Located at the heart of campus, Hurst Hall has three floors for classrooms and department offices. It has long been described as "a vital center for learning, housing various academic departments and serving as a venue for lectures, seminars, and discussions that spark intellectual curiosity and foster academic achievement" (ghostsofdc 2012). Hurst is a physical site of knowledge production, and yet, it is ADA-non-compliant (Apostol 2024).

The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) was passed in 1990 following a decades long civil rights movement for disabled communities. Despite the common misconception that historic buildings do not have to be ADA compliant, Title III of the ADA specifically notes that there is no "grandfather clause." In other words, structures built before the ADA was passed are not exempt from ADA standards. This includes private institutions, like American University, because under Title III places of public accommodation<sup>1</sup> must be ADA compliant no matter their age (tpinedo 2023). Hurst Hall is non-compliant because, despite being required under Title III, it has not been updated to meet the minimum accessibility requirements. It does not have an accessible public entry, nor does it have an elevator for disabled students to access the only bathrooms, located in the basement. Yet classes are still held in this building. If a disabled student with mobility impairments is scheduled for a class in Hurst Hall, the student is expected to reach out to the Academic Support and Access Center (ASAC) for assistance. In most cases, including the experience of my very own student, ASAC responds with the following options: 1)

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<sup>1</sup> "A "place of public accommodation" is a facility operated by a private entity whose operations effect commerce and that falls within at least one of twelve categories including places of lodging, establishments serving food and drink, and places of recreation, among others. *See* 28 C.F.R. § 36.104" (tpinedo 2023).

switch into a different session of the class, or 2) in the case that there is only one class session, drop the class and take it the following semester (with the hopes that it is scheduled in a different building). In other words, the student can either re-plan their entire schedule to accommodate the change in course times OR remove themselves from a space of knowledge production. The third, unstated option, is to figure out a way to attend class despite inaccessibility as my own student did. In all three cases, the student is responsible for navigating the failure of the institution they are paying thousands of dollars to attend each semester.

To not be able to access a classroom is epistemic disablement. The built world effectively removes (or damn near tries) the possibility for an “individual or group of individuals to engage in fair epistemic interactions and to successfully make fruitful epistemic contributions” (Catala et al. 2021, 9031). At the individual level this is epistemic disablement. However, compounded over time, space, and sociality, this is an epistemic injustice that informs inaccessible design, and therefore inaccessible spaces.

As a result of such hinderances, disabled epistemic agents are barred from contributing knowledge to mainstream hermeneutics. Of all the rendered injustices resulting from epistemic disablement, it is the mutual reproduction of inaccessible spaces that I am concerned with. I find the relationship between knowledge and design to be mutually constitutive because those that design the built world (i.e., architects, urban planners, etc.) know only that which is accessible to them. If the designers/architects are not themselves disabled, nor do they have a close tie to someone who is disabled, then they are unlikely to know the consequences of their normative-centered designs. This cycle is ongoing and bleeds into every crevice of society.

## Section Three: Seeing the Invisible Communities

In this section I will continue to pull-on real-world cases for the purpose of highlighting how ableist norms and inaccessible architecture are mutually reinforcing. Specifically, I will examine the public sphere as a place both of knowledge production and epistemic disablement.



**FIGURE 1: THE CAPITOL CRAWL (PBS 2025)**

Academic institutions are not the only sites for knowledge production. Figure 1 depicts the iconic disability rights protest in which hundreds of disabled Americans came to the U.S. Capitol and crawled up the steps to the door of the Peoples House (PBS 2025). This was both a demand for access and a resistance to erasure. By crawling up all 83 of the Capitol's steps, protestors exemplified the narrow and inaccessible design of the built world. They also refused to be invisible, showing up in the hundreds to prove that the problem of inaccessibility and ableism affected way more people than anyone (non-disabled) knew. I have included the photo of this iconic act of resistance and protest to prove that the built world regulates epistemic production beyond academic walls. Moreover, I use this example to call attention to the public sphere and its role in unjust epistemic and architectural production.

Public spaces are not only made inaccessible by physical obstructions to participation, but by juridical and governmental obstructions that invisibilize disabled beings, causing the absence of their knowledge contribution from mainstream hermeneutics, and therefore reinforcing ableist design. Take for instance the case of Martin Oates.

In July 1867, former Union soldier Martin Oates was arrested in San Francisco on the count of begging. Oates, a veteran disabled in combat, was taken into custody for breaching the nascent San Francisco law prohibiting certain persons from street begging and appearing in streets and public places. It is significant not only because of its attempt to remove lower-class individuals from the streets, but for the language folded into the ordinance itself, intending to rid streets of disabled individuals. The ordinance allowing for the arrest of Oates deemed any person “diseased, maimed, mutilated, or in any way deformed” as “perfect wrecks,” thereby codifying the first *Ugly Law* into U.S. State history (Schweik 2009, 2). Following in suite of San Francisco, *Ugly Laws* began popping up across the U.S. as “a kind of civic contagion” (Schweik 2009, 4). *Ugly Laws* are part of the “certain strong and unified project shared by and across various city cultures, involving both a judgement about bodily aesthetics and the use of law to repress the visibility of human diversity in social contexts associated with disability and poverty” (Schweik 2009, 3). For over one hundred years (1867 – 1974) *Ugly Laws*, erected and maintained across the United States, restricted visibly disabled individuals from public places.

In Oates’ case, the physical world was demarcated with invisible borders established and reinforced by the legal system. Such borders, although not entirely physical, caused similar epistemic disablement. Because of the epistemic disablement, the physical construction of the public sphere during the time in which *Ugly Laws* were in effect, largely excluded the accessibility needs of disabled people. Following the codification of the ADA and the removal of

the last *Ugly Laws* in the U.S., architects and disability activists began to co-create regulations that could be placed on all new architectural projects, requiring buildings to be accessible to everyone. They call this Universal Design.

## Section Four: Centering the Periphery with Universal Design

Universal Design is a methodology created to eliminate the threat of architectural disability to all users regardless of their biological impairment (Goldsmith 2000). The approach diagrammed in Figure 2 is of the universal design pyramid. This figure breaks corporeal variability

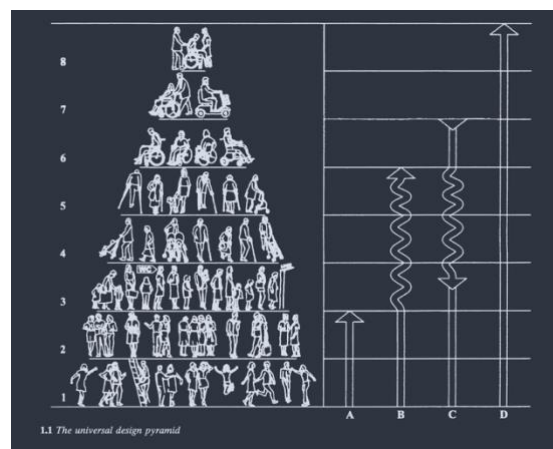


FIGURE 2 (GOLDSMITH 2000)

into eight tiers. The first section represents individuals who are fully independent and mobile, and the eighth section represents those who require two or more aids to meet basic needs such as using the restroom. The idea of a top-down model of universal design would be to construct spaces that accommodate those with the highest needs, tier 8. In the designing of public restrooms, a universal top-down model would enforce stall width to be wide enough for a wheelchair user and one other person to enter and comfortably move within the stall. The bathroom sinks would vary in height as well, allowing those in wheelchairs to reach the sink while also providing a comfortable option for taller individuals. The design requirements within the universal model are considerate of embodied differences that may impair one's mobility. However, application of minimum width requirements is not the only kind of architectural design

that makes spaces more accessible for corporeal variability. While universal design attempts to construct spaces that any user can navigate, the curation of spaces for specific disabled communities should also be considered in the development of public spaces.

Situated in NE Washington D.C. between Florida Ave and New York Ave, lies Gallaudet University, the United States first and only school for the advanced education of Deaf, Hard of Hearing, DeafBlind, and DeafDisabled students (Gallaudet Univ., n.d.). Gallaudet University (GU) was founded in 1864 with President Abraham Lincoln's signage of the private federal charter (Cordano 2018). Since this signing, GU has been at the forefront of historic disability rights progress. One of its most recent successes has been the implementation of universal design in constructing an on-campus Starbucks. This Starbucks is unique for its thoughtful and accessible design and staffing (Weinstock 2022). Physically, the layout of the Starbucks allows the entire space to be seen no matter where one is standing. This design allows Deaf users and employees to safely navigate the space without architectural visual obstructions. Unlike other Starbucks where background music blends with the sound of espresso machines buzzing, in the Gallaudet Starbucks music is replaced with a quite yet lively atmosphere. This choice is practical because it makes it a low-stimulation environment, allowing Hard of Hearing individual's and other noise-sensitive folk to navigate auditory interactions with ease. Additionally, the management has intentionally hired ASL using employees. Not only is this space well-designed, but it is also successful, making it an excellent case supporting universal and accessible architectural design (Weinstock 2022).

## Conclusion

This paper has argued that disability is not merely a bodily state nor a stable social category, but a historically, politically, and materially produced identity that must be understood

genealogically. Through this lens, the built world is revealed not as a neutral backdrop to human activity but as an active participant in shaping the conditions under which knowledge is produced, shared, and accessed. By tracing how inaccessible architecture and exclusionary norms take shape within the public sphere, I have shown that the built environment can itself enact epistemic oppression—hindering disabled people’s ability to contribute to, participate in, and be recognized within spaces of knowledge production.

Examining the built world through social epistemology made clear that accessibility is not an auxiliary concern but a constitutive feature of knowledge production. When public spaces—whether a historic classroom building or a city street governed by *Ugly Laws*—exclude disabled people, they do more than limit physical movement; they regulate epistemic participation. The result is epistemic disablement: a structural condition in which disabled individuals are denied full standing as epistemic agents, not because of any inherent limitation, but because the world has been built without them in mind.

Understanding disability genealogically exposes how these exclusions are not accidental failures but the product of longstanding ideological commitments to bodily normativity, productivity, and competence. It also reveals that inaccessible spaces are both the consequence of these ideologies and the mechanisms by which they are continually reinforced. Built environments and dominant epistemologies are thus co-constitutive: each shapes and sustains the other.

Yet the emergence and success of universal design demonstrates that the built world can be otherwise. When architecture is approached not as a set of minimum standards to comply with but as an opportunity for collective flourishing, the conditions of epistemic participation shift.

Universal design, especially when informed by disabled knowledge, refuses the logic of accommodation and instead centers bodyminds historically relegated to the periphery. In doing so, it models what an accessible public sphere might look like—one that is spatially, temporally, and discursively unbounded.

Ultimately, recognizing the built world as an epistemic agent foregrounds the urgency of reimagining places of knowledge production. If these spaces are to function as sites of knowledge production, then accessibility cannot remain a secondary concern or a technical add-on. It must be treated as foundational to the production of shared knowledge. A world that includes disabled people by design is not simply more accessible; it is more epistemically just.



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